

Movie Director, Anyone?

Inspired by all the cool-looking film and music videos you see? In this day and age there are plenty of software available that make movie making child's play. For instance, VCD Cutter, VCD Gear, and Virtual Dub are software that help you make your own customised movies and we're not talking about the illegal copying of movies.

These software help you cut short sequences from video files so you can build a personal collection of your favourite scenes and video clips. Using the basic video editing features offered by these software, you can even weave clips from different videos and 'make' your own film—something like a collage of video sequences.

your hard drive where they are readily available. 'Ripping' audio CDs to other more compact music formats is quite popular nowadays and this is where MP3, WMA and Ogg Vorbis come in.

There are many different software that allow you to 'rip' CDs, such as Windows Media Player, Real Jukebox, Audiograbber (Jet Audio) and Musicmatch. Says Siddharth Siva, a photographer, "I use Musicmatch to rip CDs and am quite happy with it. It's simple to use and I like the interface."

The basic (and free) version of Musicmatch, which is one of the more popular 'jukeboxes' around, allows you to rip CDs at bitrates of 128 Kbps, which is near CD quality. It also has other useful features such as an inbuilt MP3 player that automatically searches for all MP3 songs on your hard disk and sorts them by artist, songs, album, etc for easy access.

You can also list songs based on other parameters such as genre, tempos, moods, situations and so on. However, for this feature to be useful, the songs need to be tagged appropriately. If you have a large collection, assigning the right genre and mood to each and every song could be a painful task.

Advanced users who are extremely particular about the quality of the output music file, prefer using software such as Digital Audio Copy which gives you output files in the Wav format with a file size of about 40 MB for each song. This requires an additional step of converting the Wav files to MP3, which you can do using MP3 Compressor. This software compresses the files to approximately 4 MB. While

transfer songs from your computer to your portable music player.

For the sake of video

When it comes to playing video on your PC, the choice seems considerably simpler. Most people tend to stick to Media Player, which supports around 27 different media formats including DAT, MP3, CDA, AVI, MPG, ASF and Wav. In addition to this, you can usually find a downloadable Codec that will enable you to play an unsupported file format, such as DivX, in Media Player.

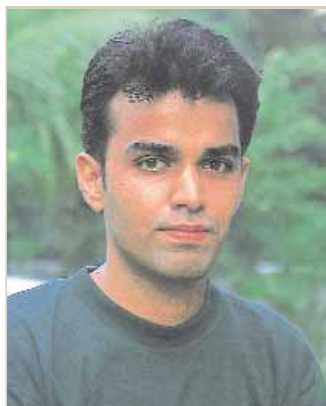
On the rare occasion where you come across a proprietary file format, you would probably need to download a player specifically for that file. One player that you are most likely to come across is Apple's QuickTime, which is quite popular for short movie clips such as trailers and ad films. These MOV files can be played on the free version of the QuickTime player that can be downloaded from www.apple.com. Another frequently used format is RealMedia (.ra or .ram), which is used mostly for streaming applications. These can be played back using the RealPlayer software, which you can download from www.real.com.

If you happen to have a DVD drive installed on your PC and enjoy feasting your senses on such movies, then players such as WinDVD and PowerDVD are ideal solutions. These software give you impeccable video quality coupled with surround sound, which can really bring a movie to life—provided you have the right set of speakers, of course. These software also let you play other common video formats.

All set to rock...

So once you have your new multimedia PC all set up, the next thing you would obviously need is a piece of software that is easy to use, supports various file formats and lets you play Metallica full blast or watch the DVD rip of *Planet of the Apes*. Well, as an audio player, Winamp seems to fulfill the needs of most users while Windows Media player is the popular choice of most people looking for both audio and video functionality. Musicmatch and Real Jukebox are also quite user friendly and a number of users have experienced Real and QuickTime players and were happy with the performance.

While all these software are widely accepted and quite popular, no software can deliver a 100 per cent. Easy availability and compatibility of features such as skin support and plugins add to the fun you can have. So depending upon your requirements, if it's the ideal music or video player that you are looking for in terms of performance and utility functions, the choice is clear enough. ■



"While Windows Media Player 7 does have good features and is a comprehensive media player, it uses substantially more systems resources"

Sanjay Bhuneja
Businessman

the process of ripping a CD may be more tedious, the clarity of music is worth the effort. "I have tried Musicmatch and a few others but have never obtained the same clarity and quality," says D'Souza.

Windows Media player is another alternative that allows you to encode files in the WMA format, which is more compact than the MP3 format. Like the other jukeboxes, it allows you to